



This is the second in our series of four special issues planned to celebrate India entering its 60th year of Independence. The first issue served as a reminder of our tumultuous past by revisiting India's last six decades as an independent nation, from the tragedy and the trauma of Partition to the progress, gradual at first—the Hindu rate of growth—then picking up economic steam despite the many conflicts that divided the country. That India survived was something of a miracle but it also showed the durability of its democratic institutions and the power that stemmed from the freedoms enshrined in our Constitution, most notably the freedom to elect the people who guided India's destiny. As our issue showed, the tragedies outnumbered the triumphs but despite that, India entered the era of economic liberalisation and coalition governments in the 1990s with an unprecedented degree of confidence and maturity.

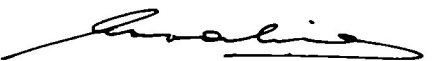
This, the second of the series, is a logical extension of that process. It represents a fascinating portrait of the country's progress through individuals, communities and institutes. Called '60 New Indias', these are essentially 60 inspirational stories that come from all over the country, from tiny villages and small towns to sprawling metropolises. They are 60 faces of our country that together constitute a compelling narrative of India as it is today, whether it is the people of Moushuni, a little village in the Sunderbans that got power after 55 years of India's Independence, or training institutes in small towns that produce airhostesses or potential engineering and medical whiz-kids. Like the teenagers who frequent cricket camps in Ranchi, daring to dream big, or the man from Bihar who made it into the IAS, battling all odds. Then there's the ageing rockstar in Shillong who continues to inspire young rockers, the theatre group in Manipur that has found its political expression through art, or the two young girls in Kerala who have learnt to protect themselves with the ancient art of Kalaripayat. The cities have changed too, their tales told through the share market, Bollywood, cafes, discotheques and the fashion industry.

It was one of our most ambitious joint efforts in recent times. Executive Editor Kaveree Bamzai coordinated the efforts of 19 correspondents who clocked over 19,000 km of travel by air, road, rickshaw, boat and bullock cart to bring alive the many facets of the New India. Principal Correspondent Swagata Sen found herself crossing the 100-km distance from Kolkata to the Sunderbans by car, boat and something called a van rickshaw which cut through paddy fields. Associate Editor Ramesh Vinayak stumbled across an old college friend while writing on Punjab's high-tech farms—Jang Bahadur Singh Sangha, who belongs to the same alma mater as Vinayak, runs an amazingly modern seed and potato farming empire.

The most fascinating experience, however, was that of Special Correspondent M.G. Radhakrishnan who travelled through obscure villages in Kerala's Malappuram district to find soccer-mad fans of international clubs. In one such village, Thirattammal, he was stunned to see flags of teams like Brazil and Argentina competing for space with CPI(M)'s red or the Muslim League's green flags. He found local clubs called Arsenal or Manchester United and even football players in Malappuram named Ronaldinho or Zidane. The climax was when he was taken to meet local football hero Jaffer, a die-hard Brazil fan, who has painted his entire brand new house in yellow and green, the Brazilian colours. The world is really getting flatter!

These are the stories that are driving modern India, some are remarkable feats of engineering, like the Delhi Metro, others are to do with the tremendous changes taking place in small towns. Then there are community self-help groups in the remote North-East, an agriculture revolution brought about by e-governance in Andhra Pradesh and an insight into how professional dancers are changing Bollywood's song routines.

India has always been an incredible country which straddles many centuries simultaneously. But in the last two decades there has been an enormous churn, brought about by faster economic growth, globalisation and technology. All this has thrown up some refreshingly interesting stories away from the daily muck of our politics. Reading these snapshots of change, which illustrate our New Indias, should leave you with a nice warm feeling.


(Aroon Purie)